



The Murray-Darling

The largest river system in Australasia with one of the most extensive catchment areas on Earth, responsible for irrigating the “food basket” of Australia



Consisting of the Murray, Australia’s longest river, and its main tributary, the Darling, the Murray–Darling river system is the largest in Australasia. Draining the southeast of Australia, its basin covers an area of more than 386,000 square miles (1 million square km)—around 14 percent of the country’s land area. The Murray–Darling basin is the most important agricultural region of a largely arid country, growing three-quarters of Australia’s irrigated crops and producing one-third of its total food supply.

From mountains to mouth

Rising in the Australian Alps, at the southern end of the Great Dividing Range, the Murray River flows across flat inland plains, forming the border between New South Wales and Victoria for much of its route. The river receives most of its main tributaries from the north along this section, including the Darling, which flows southwest across almost the whole length of New South

The Murray-Darling is thought to be the **driest major river system** in the world

Wales from its source near the Queensland border. Both the Murray and Darling have very low gradients over most of their lengths, resulting in slow, meandering waterways.

After the Murray–Darling confluence, the river enters South Australia and flows through ancient gorges with towering sandstone cliffs separated by a series of shallow lakes. Having flowed a distance of 1,570 miles (2,530 km) from the source of the Murray, the river discharges into the Southern Ocean through a dynamic, sand-dune-flanked point known as Murray Mouth, at the eastern end of the Great Australian Bight.



△ FRESHWATER TURTLE

The eastern long-necked turtle has webbed feet and is able to stay underwater for long periods. Unlike other turtles and tortoises, it pulls its neck sideways into its shell.